

VIDHAN SABHA
Lucknow

The winter session of the Uttar Pradesh assembly came to a close on November 30, and it created a record of sorts. Since the Yogi Adityanath-led government started its second term in March 2022, a total of seven assembly sessions (including one special session) have been held till now, but not a single day has had to be adjourned due to disruptions by members.

This is the first time since Independence that seven consecutive sessions have passed off peacefully and the man behind this is assembly Speaker Satish Mahana, 63. He explains the reason for this relative peace: "Earlier, the time allotted for speaking to the parties was fixed on the basis of the number of MLAs in the house. I have stopped this tradition and have given equal time to the ruling and opposition MLAs. Also, the number of supplementary questions that can be asked by members was fixed at two. This helped members get more answers from the treasury benches and increased the confidence of opposition members in the House."

The Speaker also introduced a unique session for just women MLAs in September 2022 where 38 female MLAs presented their views. In the special session that lasted eight hours, Mahana called many women MLAs including the Samajwadi Party's Syeda Khatoon to take the speaker's seat and lead the proceedings.

An eight-time MLA from Kanpur, Mahana was elected unopposed as speaker of the 18th UP assembly. In his first meeting with officials, the new Speaker fixed the deadline for implementing the e-legislation system. Within a month, the 400-odd tablets were installed on the seats of all the MLAs. On May 20, 2022, the UP assembly plan to make proceedings of paperless came true. On May 23, 2022, a paperless budget was presented.

Mahana has also got the seating issue resolved. In the House of 403 members, there was seating arrangement for only 379 members earlier. Before the 2022 budget session, seating arrangements were made for 417 members in the House. Now, during House proceedings, as soon as a member stands up to speak, his complete profile is displayed on the two TV screens in the House while a countdown timer shows the member how much time he has. The Vidhan Bhavan building has also had a face-lift, which includes facade lights that can change colours.

"I now give equal time to the opposition members to speak, which has increased their confidence and reduced disruptions"

Satish Mahana
UP assembly speaker

Speaker Mahana's efforts haven't stopped there. He has also taken an interest in upgrading the image of the MLAs. So a list of legislators with professional degrees like doctors, engineers and MBAs have been made and separate meetings held with them. For the first time, a tradition of celebrating the birthdays of MLAs has also been started during assembly sessions. A coffee lobby has also built so that the MLAs do not have to leave the House proceedings to visit the canteen. As expected, all this has had an ameliorating effect on the house sessions. The UP assembly, once known for its rowdyness, is now a lot more peaceful with proceedings moving along unhindered. ■

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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

- **The UP assembly created a record of sorts, no adjournments due to disruptions in the past seven sessions, the first time this has happened since Independence**
- **Speaker Mahana has brought in many innovations, including women-only special house sessions, fixed and equal time for members' speeches, and fixing the seating arrangements in the House**
- **The Vidhan Sabha is also now paperless, with the e-legislation system set up**

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